

MANDYC. · CAPITAL MARKETS ADVISORY

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# The Executive Readiness Diagnostic

*A 10-minute self-assessment for executives whose companies are preparing to raise, restructure, or list.*

MANDY CHEUNG · SFC TYPE 6 LICENSED  
60+ TRANSACTIONS · US\$200M+ IN DEAL VALUE  
HKEX & NASDAQ

# Most companies don't fail at the capital event itself.

They fail in the 6 to 18 months leading up to it.

Lawyers catch structural gaps. Auditors catch financial ones. The gaps that actually kill the raise or the listing live somewhere else: in the leader.

The CEO who can't hold the line when a board member pushes hard. The founder who freezes when due diligence surfaces something ugly. The executive whose decision quality degrades as pressure compresses. The leader running on adrenaline by month 14.

*This diagnostic surfaces those gaps. Not in your cap table. In you.*

It won't tell you what your auditor should tell you. It will show you where your leadership will be tested when the deal gets hard, and whether your current operating system can hold it.

## HOW TO USE THIS

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# 5 dimensions. 5 scored questions. 5 reflection prompts.

Each dimension has three layers:

**Score.** One question, scored 0 to 3. Be honest. There's no prize for inflating.

**Reflect.** A prompt that points you at your own experience. Not scored. No right answer. What you notice is data.

**Learn.** An insight based on patterns across 60+ capital-market transactions. This is what typically shows up in a deal room when a leader carries this gap.

**Total time:** 10 minutes.

**Total possible score:** 15 points.

Your score determines your readiness band, and what kind of work sits between you and the capital event.

## Capital Narrative Conviction

Your equity story isn't a slide deck. It's a nervous system event. When a sophisticated investor pushes back on your valuation, your body responds before your mind catches up. The leader who holds the story under pressure isn't the one with better data. It's the one whose conviction lives deeper than the script.

### SCORE

*When you state your company's valuation to a room of sophisticated investors, where does your conviction come from?*

- 0 From the deck. If someone challenges the numbers, I reach for new data.
- 1 From rehearsal. The words are right but I can feel the performance.
- 2 From the business itself. I believe it. Under hard pushback, I sometimes waver.
- 3 From somewhere I can't be talked out of. I've been pushed hard and the story held. Not because I was stubborn. Because I'd done the work.

### REFLECT

*Think about the last time you stated your valuation out loud. Where did you feel it in your body? Any tightening? Any impulse to qualify or hedge? That's data.*

### WHAT THIS DIMENSION REVEALS

The risk isn't your pitch. It's that your investor can feel the gap between your words and your conviction. Sophisticated capital reads the room before it reads the deck. The work isn't a better presentation. It's closing the gap between what you say and what you believe.

## Decision-Making Under Pressure

A capital event compresses decision timelines. Term sheets arrive Friday with a Monday answer expected. Due diligence surfaces something ugly the week before signing. The leader who freezes or defaults to reactive thinking costs the company money or the deal itself. The question isn't whether pressure comes. It's what your nervous system does in the first 60 seconds.

### SCORE

*When the deal compresses (term sheet, DD finding, walk-away threat), what happens first?*

- 0 I react before I think. The first call I make is usually the wrong one.
- 1 I feel the hit. I recover in hours, not minutes. First day is messy.
- 2 I take a beat. I respond strategically. I sometimes notice reactivity underneath.
- 3 I hold state. I've trained for this. The response comes from clarity, not adrenaline.

### REFLECT

*Think about the last time a high-pressure decision landed without warning. What did your body do first? That response, before the strategic mind kicked in, is the real answer.*

### WHAT THIS DIMENSION REVEALS

Your deal team already knows. They've seen the reactive call, the decision reversed 48 hours later, the meeting where the energy shifted because you were unsettled. The risk isn't one bad decision. It's that your state becomes the deal room's weather.

## Board and Investor Communication

Sophisticated capital tests the leader through pushback. A board member's bad idea. An investor's overreach. A co-investor's pressure to accept worse terms. The leader who can't hold the line loses leverage that doesn't come back. The skill is holding the line while staying in relationship.

### SCORE

*When you disagree with a board member or investor on something that matters, what happens?*

- 0 I fold. Holding the line feels like risking the relationship.
- 1 I push back, but it costs something. I walk away drained.
- 2 I hold the line. The relationship survives. Sometimes barely.
- 3 I hold the line as standard. They know I'll tell them the truth. It deepens the relationship.

### REFLECT

*Think about the last time you disagreed with someone who had more leverage than you. Did you say what you actually thought, or a version of it? Notice what you edited out.*

### WHAT THIS DIMENSION REVEALS

You're leaking leverage in every board meeting and investor conversation. Sophisticated capital doesn't respect the leader who agrees. It respects the leader it can't push past when that leader is right. Every time you fold on something you know is wrong, the message is: this person can be moved.

# Personal Operating System

A capital event is an 18-month compression. The leader without a real operating system breaks somewhere: burnout, home, or the deal itself. Discipline, state control, and recovery aren't soft. They're load-bearing. They're the infrastructure that keeps judgment intact when everything else is compressing.

## SCORE

*Under sustained pressure (months, not days), does your system hold or start to break?*

- 0 It breaks. I run on adrenaline and willpower. Recovery happens when something breaks first.
- 1 I have habits that help when things are calm. They disappear when things get hard.
- 2 I have an operating system that mostly holds. It bends. I adjust.
- 3 My system is built for compression. It holds at the worst. Non-negotiable, not preference.

## REFLECT

*What broke first during the last sustained high-pressure window? Sleep? Decision quality? The closest relationship? The thing that breaks first is the thing your current system doesn't protect.*

## WHAT THIS DIMENSION REVEALS

You're running on a depreciating asset. Willpower has a half-life. The expensive mistake in month 14 doesn't happen because you got less smart. It happens because your operating system couldn't sustain the load. The leader who treats discipline and recovery as optional is the leader who makes the call they can't take back.

## Strategic Clarity

The capital event is a tool, not a goal. The leader who forgets that optimizes for the raise itself. By then, the deal has reshaped the company in ways nobody wanted. Hiring, spending, structuring: all bent toward the raise instead of the business the raise was meant to build.

### SCORE

*Is the capital event a tool in service of a thesis, or has it become the thesis itself?*

- 0 The capital event is the goal. Everything else is organized around getting it done.
- 1 I have a thesis, but the capital event has become the primary filter for decisions.
- 2 The thesis is clear. The capital event mostly serves it. There's some drift.
- 3 The thesis is clear. The capital event is a means. I'd walk away from a bad version of it.

### REFLECT

*If the capital event disappeared tomorrow, what would your company be optimizing for?  
If you can't answer that cleanly, the deal has already reshaped the strategy.*

### WHAT THIS DIMENSION REVEALS

The deal has become the destination instead of the vehicle. Decisions are being made that serve the raise, not the business the raise was meant to build. The leader who can't articulate what the company is for, independent of the capital event, is building a company shaped by the deal.

## YOUR SCORE

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# Total possible: 15 points.

5 questions × 3 max. Your readiness band, and what sits between you and the capital event:

### 0-4 · FOUNDATION PHASE

You're not ready to lead a capital event yet. The gaps are foundational. Pushing forward now risks the company and the deal. The work isn't structural company work. It's leader work. Look at your lowest-scoring dimension. Then read that reflection prompt again. What you noticed there is the entry point.

### 5-8 · QUARTERLY ENGAGEMENT TERRITORY

You're roughly 12 months out. The foundation is there. Specific gaps remain: a narrative not yet pressure-tested, a decision pattern that needs sharpening, an operating system that bends too much under compression. One quarter of focused work compresses the timeline meaningfully. This is the band where most leaders sit before a serious capital event.

### 9-12 · SHARPENING TERRITORY

You're close. The remaining gaps are tactical, not foundational. One dimension probably scored lower than the others. The work is targeted: tighten the weak link before it shows up in a deal room.

### 13-15 · MANDATE TERRITORY

You're ready to execute. The conversation isn't about readiness. It's about the deal itself: structure, timing, counterparties, terms.

# Your total tells you how far out you are.

Your lowest dimension tells you what will be tested first.

Look at where you scored lowest. That's the gap that surfaces under real deal pressure. Not because the other dimensions don't matter. Because this is the one your current system doesn't cover.

*If you want to talk through what you found, book a call at [mandyc.me](https://mandyc.me). The call is for fit exploration, not a pitch.*

## ABOUT

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# Mandy Cheung

Mandy Cheung is a capital markets advisor based in Hong Kong. SFC Type 6 licensed, 10+ years across HKEX and NASDAQ, 60+ transactions, US\$200M+ in deal value. She works with executives running companies that are preparing to raise, restructure, or list. Her work sits at the intersection of capital strategy and the leader's operating system.

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*This diagnostic is for informational purposes. It is not legal, tax, or investment advice.*